

Say It Anyway



Say It Anyway

A Teen Journal for Social Anxiety & Shyness

NORTH STAR JOURNALS

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This journal is intended for self-reflection and general well-being. It is not a substitute for professional mental-health care. If you are struggling, please reach out to a trusted adult, counselor, or crisis line. In the U.S., call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline). Outside the U.S., see findahelpline.com.

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For everyone who has ever rehearsed a hello.

HOW TO USE THIS JOURNAL

This is your journal. Nothing in it is a test, and there is no wrong way to use it. Some pages will hit exactly right on a hard day. Others will feel like nothing. That is normal. Move on.

There are five sections inside. Grounding tools you can use in the moment, when your body is in the middle of it. Prompts to help you get the loud thoughts out of your head and onto paper, where they get a little smaller. Trackers to help you notice patterns — what triggers your anxiety, what actually helps, how sleep and mood connect. A toolkit of small practices for the hard days. And eight weeks of short reflections at the end.

You do not have to go in order. If a prompt feels wrong today, turn to another one. If a tracker doesn't fit your week, skip it. Progress is not linear, and neither is this book.

A few small suggestions:

- If your mind is loud, start with a grounding tool from Section One. Sometimes your body has to steady before your thoughts will.

- Try one prompt a day for a week, then look back. You'll see patterns you couldn't see in the moment.
- Try one tracker for a full week before deciding whether it helps. Patterns take time to show up on the page.
- Write in pencil, pen, marker, whatever. Scribble. Doodle in the margins. Leave a page half-empty. This journal will not grade you.
- If you fill a page and want more room, use one of the notes pages at the back. They're there on purpose.

One important thing: this journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe — please also talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a mental-health professional. There are resources at the back of the book. You do not have to do this alone.

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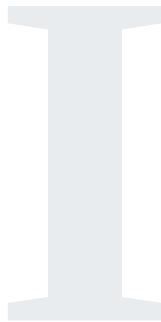
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SECTION ONE

Start Here

Five grounding tools you can use anywhere.



PRACTICE

5-4-3-2-1

A classic sensory grounding exercise. When your thoughts are racing faster than you can catch them, your senses can pull you back into your body. Take your time with each step. There is no rush.

1. Name five things you can SEE. Say them out loud or in your head.
2. Name four things you can TOUCH. Actually touch them if you can.
3. Name three things you can HEAR. Distant sounds count too.
4. Name two things you can SMELL. Or two smells you like.
5. Name one thing you can TASTE. Or one taste you'd like right now.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Box breathing

A simple breath pattern used by athletes, first responders, and anyone who needs to steady a racing nervous system. Four counts in, four hold, four out, four hold. Draw a square in the air with your finger as you go — one side per count.

1. Breathe in slowly through your nose for four counts.
2. Hold your breath gently for four counts.
3. Breathe out slowly through your mouth for four counts.
4. Hold empty for four counts. That's one full cycle.
5. Repeat four times. Notice how your body feels different at the end.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Body scan

Anxiety lives in the body — tight jaw, clenched shoulders, shallow breath. A slow scan helps you locate where you're holding it, so you can start to let it go. There is no wrong way to do this.

1. Start at the top of your head. Notice how it feels.
2. Move down slowly: forehead, jaw, neck, shoulders.
3. Continue down: chest, belly, arms, hands, hips.
4. Keep going: legs, knees, ankles, feet.
5. Where do you feel tight? Let it soften if it wants to. If it doesn't, that's okay too.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

A temperature shift is one of the fastest ways to interrupt an anxiety spiral. Cold on the face triggers the mammalian dive reflex, which slows your heart rate on purpose. Sounds strange. Works fast.

- ## WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Name it to tame it

Vague, big feelings feel unmanageable. Specific, named feelings feel smaller. Being precise about your emotion shrinks it a little and gives you something to actually work with.

1. Pause. Ask: what am I actually feeling right now?
2. Skip 'bad.' Try more specific words: anxious, angry, disappointed, embarrassed, lonely.
3. Say it out loud or write it down: 'I feel _____ because _____.'
4. See if you can name a second feeling underneath the first one.
5. Notice — did naming it change the size of it at all?

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

SECTION TWO

Prompts

Small pages for the moments before you speak.



NO. 01

What social situation is on your mind right now? Describe it in detail.

NO. 03

Write out a conversation you're rehearsing. What are you afraid they'll say?

NO. 04

What did you almost say today but didn't? What would have happened if you had?

NO. 05

Who feels easy to be around? What is it about them that makes it easy?

NO. 06

What is a compliment you've never known how to accept? Try accepting it here.

NO. 07

Describe your ideal version of a party or gathering. Who's there? What do you do?

NO. 08

What is one small social risk you could take this week? What's the smallest version of it?

NO. 09

*Write about a time you felt awkward and everyone survived.
What actually happened?*

NO. 10

What do you wish people knew about you that they usually don't?

NO. 12

Who would you like to know better? What is one question you could ask them?

NO. 14

What do you assume other people are thinking about you? Are you sure?

NO. 15

Write about someone who made you feel seen. What did they do, exactly?

NO. 16

What is a group you feel out of place in? Is that group actually the wrong fit?

NO. 17

What is one thing you like about how you show up around other people?

NO. 18

What would you say if you weren't worried about how it sounded?

NO. 19

What is a memory of you being funny, warm, or interesting that you tend to dismiss?

NO. 20

Who would be lucky to have you as a friend? What would you bring to that friendship?

NO. 21

What are you tired of pretending to feel around other people?

NO. 23

What is a text you've been meaning to send? Draft it here. Then decide.

NO. 24

Write about a time you set a boundary. How did it feel? What happened?

NO. 25

What would you do at lunch this week if you weren't worried about looking alone?

NO. 26

Who are you around when you feel most like yourself? What are you doing?

NO. 27

What is one hard thing you want to say to someone? Practice it here.

NO. 28

What does 'good enough' look like for a conversation? Not perfect. Just good enough.

NO. 29

Finish this: 'The version of me who isn't anxious around people would...'

NO. 30

Write yourself permission to leave early, be quiet, or say no this week.

SECTION THREE

Trackers

Notice the patterns in your social situations.



TRACKER

Anxiety level this week

Rate your baseline anxiety each day. Note what set it off and what helped.

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT TRIGGERED IT	WHAT HELPED
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Sleep tracker

How many hours, how well, and how you felt the next day. Patterns show up fast.

DAY	HOURS SLEPT	QUALITY 1-10	HOW I FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Mood check-in

Three quick check-ins each day. One word each is enough.

DAY	MORNING	AFTERNOON	NIGHT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Social Situations log

Notice when it shows up. What was happening? What did you do next?

DAY	WHEN AND WHERE	BODY FEELING	WHAT I DID NEXT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Energy this week

What drained you. What refilled you. Both matter.

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT DRAINED ME	WHAT REFILLED ME
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

One small win

Every day, name one small thing. Toast that wasn't burnt counts.

DAY	WIN OF THE DAY	WHO NOTICED	HOW IT FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Kindness to self

One kind thing you did for yourself each day. Rest counts. Naps count.

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

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Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SECTION FOUR

Your Toolkit

Small practices you can return to on hard days.



PRACTICE

The 3-second opener

Write down three low-pressure openers you could actually use this week: 'Hey.' 'How's your week going?' 'What did you think of...?' Pick one.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Rehearse the exit

Write your polite exit line. 'I've got to head out — good seeing you.' Practice having it ready so leaving feels like a plan, not a panic.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Reframe the mind-read

Write down what you assume someone is thinking about you. Then write three other explanations for what they might actually be thinking.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The tiny risk

Pick one social risk this week that's a 2/10, not a 9/10. Wave.
Compliment. Ask a small question. Write which one and when.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Post-mortem, kindly

After a hard social moment, write what happened. Then write what you'd tell a friend who described this exact same moment to you.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The 'me too' list

Write down every awkward thing you're sure only you feel. Realize most people feel these. Circle the ones a friend has also mentioned.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Ask a question

The easiest thing to say in a hard conversation is a real question. Write three questions you could ask someone this week.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Boundary draft

Draft a boundary you want to set. Short, kind, clear. 'I can't tonight.' 'I need to head home.' 'Please don't joke about that.' Practice it.

TRY IT NOW.

Before a social event, write down: when you'll leave, how you'll get home, and what you'll do to recover after. Plans make it possible to go.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Small brag

Write down one thing you did socially this week that took courage — however small. Waving. Sending the text. Sitting with someone. That counts.

TRY IT NOW.

AFFIRMATIONS

Write down phrases that feel true (or that you want to be true). Circle the ones that help most. Come back to them.

- I am not everyone's cup of tea, and that is okay.
- Being quiet is not the same as being wrong.
- One warm sentence is enough.
- I can leave when I need to.
- I do not have to earn my place at the table.
- People are thinking about themselves, not me.
- It is okay to take a while to open up.
- I am allowed to like who I like and skip who I don't.

NOTES

SECTION FIVE

Weekly Reflections

Eight weeks of looking back and forward.



PRACTICE

Week 1 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 1 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 2 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 2 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 3 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 3 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 4 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 4 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 5 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 5 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 6 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 6 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 7 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 7 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 8 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 8 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

WHEN YOU NEED MORE HELP

This journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe, please talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a therapist.

If you are in crisis:

- U.S. — Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).
- U.S. — Text HOME to 741741 (Crisis Text Line).
- U.K. — Call 116 123 (Samaritans).
- Global — findahelpline.com lists lines in your country.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

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